Barrington Bunny

By Martin Bell

NARRATOR: **(Pgs 1-8)** Once upon a time in a large forest there lived a very furry bunny. He had one lop ear, a tiny black nose, and unusually shiny eyes. His name was Barrington. Barrington was not really a very handsome bunny. He was brown and speckled and his ears didn't stand up right. But he could hop, and he was, as I have said, very furry.

[Now] winter is fun for bunnies. After all, it gives them an opportunity to hop in the snow and then turn around to see where they have hopped. So, in a way, winter was fun for Barrington. But in another way winter made Barrington sad. For, you see, winter marked the time where all of the animal families got together in their cozy homes to celebrate Christmas. He could hop, and he was very furry. But as far as Barrington knew, he was the only bunny in the forest.

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INTRODUCTION

Christmas is a time for telling stories. Some are ancient stories: stories about shepherds and angels and a baby born in a cow's manger. some of them are stories from our childhood - stories of elves and flying reindeer, of snowmen who come to life under the spell of Christmas magic, and of Santa Claus. Still each season brings new stories, stories that capture for us in a new way some of the miracles of the first story. So often the story of Jesus is portrayed as a kind of romantic, sentimental tale. It is forgotten how marvelous and how expensive a gift Christmas really is, that the manger and the cross are made of the same wood; that this small child was sent not just to be a gift, another trinket for us to wear around our necks for a season, but was sent to die for us, to show us what God's love is all about.

Martin Bell, in his story Barrington Bunny, reminds children everywhere of the power of love and sacrifice.

NARRATOR: When Christmas Eve finally came, Barrington did not feel like going home all by himself. So, he decided he would hop for a while in the clearing at the center of the forest. Hop. Hop. Hippity-hop. Barrington made tracks in the fresh snow. Hop. Hop. Hippity-hop. Then he cocked his head and looked back at the wonderful designs he had made.

BARRINGTON: Bunnies can hop. And they are very warm, too, because of how furry they are.

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NARRATOR: But Barrington didn't really know whether or not this was true of all bunnies, since he had never met another bunny

When it got too dark to see the tracks he was making, Barrington made up his mind to go home. On his way, however, he passed a large oak tree. High in the branches there was a great deal of excited chattering going on. Barrington looked up. It was a squirrel family! What a marvelous time they seemed to be having.

BARRINGTON: Hello, up there!

SQUIRREL: Hello, down there!

BARRINGTON: Having a Christmas party?"

SQUIRREL: Oh, yes! It's Christmas Eve. Everybody is having a Christmas party!

BARRINGTON: *(softly)* May I come to your party?

SQUIRREL: Are you a squirrel?

BARRINGTON: No.

SQUIRREL: What are you, then?

BARRINGTON: A bunny.

SQUIRREL: A bunny? Well, how can you come to the party if you're a bunny? Bunnies can't climb trees.

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BARRINGTON: *(thoughtfully)* That's true. But I can hop and I'm very furry and warm.

SQUIRREL: We're sorry. We don't know anything about hopping and being furry, but we do know that in order to come to our house you have to be able to climb trees.

BARRINGTON: Oh, well. Merry Christmas.

SQUIRREL: Merry Christmas.

NARRATOR: And the unfortunate bunny hopped off toward his tiny house. It was beginning to snow when Barrington reached the river. Near the riverbank was a wonderfully constructed house of sticks and mud. Inside there was singing. *(sing, beaver-style)*

BARRINGTON: It's the beavers! Maybe they will let me come to their party. *(knocks on the door)*

BEAVER: Who's out there?

BARRINGTON: Barrington Bunny

NARRATOR: There was a long pause and then a shiny beaver head broke the water.

BEAVER: Hello, Barrington.

BARRINGTON: May I come to your Christmas party?

BEAVER: *(thinks for a moment)* I suppose so. Do you know how to swim?

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BARRINGTON: No, but I can hop and I am very furry and warm.

BEAVER: Sorry, I don't know anything about hopping and being furry, but I do know that in order to come to our house you have to be able to swim.

BARRINGTON: *(eyes filling with tears)* Oh, well, I suppose that's true. Merry Christmas.

BEAVER: Merry Christmas!

NARRATOR: And he disappeared beneath the surface of the water. Even as furry as he was, Barrington was starting to get cold. And the snow was falling so hard that his tiny, bunny eyes could scarcely see what was ahead of him. He was almost home, however, when he heard the excited squeaking of field mice beneath the ground.

BARRINGTON: It's a party! *(blurting out through his tears)* Hello, field mice. This is Barrington Bunny. May I come to your party?

NARRATOR: But the wind was howling so loudly and Barrington was sobbing so much that no one heard him. And when there was no response at all, Barrington just sat down in the snow and began to cry with all his might.

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BARRINGTON: *(sobbing)* Bunnies aren't any good to anyone. What good is it to be furry and to be able to hop if you don't have any family on Christmas Eve?

NARRATOR: Barrington cried and cried. When he stopped crying he began to bite on his bunny's foot, but he did not move from where he was sitting in the snow. Suddenly, Barrington was aware he was not alone. He looked up and strained his shiny eyes to see who was there. To his surprise he saw a great silver wolf. The wolf was large and strong and his eyes flashed fire. He was the most beautiful animal Barrington had ever seen.

For a long time the silver wolf didn't say anything at all. He just stood there and looked at Barrington with those terrible eyes. Then slowly and deliberately the wolf spoke.

WOLF: *(in a gentle voice)* Barrington, why are you sitting in the snow?

BARRINGTON: Because it's Christmas Eve, and I don't have any family, and bunnies aren't any good to anyone.

WOLF: Bunnies are, too, good. Bunnies can hop and they are very warm.

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BARRINGTON: *(sniffing)* What good is that?

WOLF: It is very good indeed because it is a gift that bunnies are given, a free gift with no strings attached. And every gift that is given to anyone is given for a reason. Someday you will see why it is good to hop and to be warm and furry.

BARRINGTON: *(moaning)* But it's Christmas and I'm all alone. I don't have any family at all.

WOLF: Of course you do. All of the animals in the forest are your family.

NARRATOR: And then the wolf disappeared. He simply wasn't there. Barrington had only blinked his eyes, and when he looked-the wolf was gone.

BARRINGTON: *(thoughtfully)* All of the animals in the forest are my family. It's good to be a bunny. Bunnies can hop. That's a gift. A gift. A free gift.

NARRATOR: On in the night Barrington worked. First he found the best stick he could. (And that was difficult because of the snow.) Then ***Hop. Hop. Hippity-hop***. To Beaver's house. He left the stick just outside the door. With a note on it that read: "Here is a good stick for your house. It is a gift. A free gift. No strings attached. Signed, a member of your family."

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BARRINGTON: It is a good thing that I can hop because the snow is very deep.

NARRATOR: Then Barrington dug and dug. Soon he had gathered together enough dead leaves and grass to make the squirrels' nest warmer. ***Hop. Hop. Hippity-hop.*** He laid the grass and leaves just under the large oak tree and attached this message: "A gift. A free gift. From a member of your family."

It was late when Barrington finally started home. And what made things worse was that he knew a blizzard was beginning. ***Hop. Hop. Hippity-hop.*** Soon poor Barrington was lost. The wind howled furiously.

BARRINGTON: It certainly is cold. It's a good thing I'm so furry. But if I don't find my way home pretty soon I might freeze!

FIELD MOUSE: Squeak. Squeak. . .

NARRATOR: And then he saw it -- a baby field mouse lost in the snow. And the little mouse was crying.

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BARRINGTON: Hello, little mouse. Don't cry. I'll be right there."

NARRATOR: ***Hippity-hop***, and Barrington was beside the tiny mouse.

FIELD MOUSE: *(sobbing)* I'm lost! I'll never find my way home, and I know I'm going to freeze.

BARRINGTON: You won't freeze. I'm a bunny and bunnies are very furry and warm. You stay right where you are and I'll cover you up.

NARRATOR: Barrington lay on top of the little mouse and hugged him tight. The tiny fellow felt himself surrounded by warm fur. He cried for a while but soon, snug and warm, he fell asleep.

Barrington had only two thoughts that long, cold night.

BARRINGTON: It's good to be a bunny. Bunnies are very furry and warm.

NARRATOR: And then, when he felt the heart of the tiny mouse beating regularly . . .

BARRINGTON: All the animals in the forest are my family.

NARRATOR: Next morning, the field mice found their little boy, asleep in the snow, warm and snug beneath the

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furry carcass of a dead bunny. Their relief and excitement was so great that they didn't even think to question where the bunny had come from. And as for the beavers and the squirrels, they still wonder which member of their family left the little gift for them that Christmas Eve.

After the field mice had left, Barrington's frozen body simply lay in the snow. There was no sound except that of the howling wind. And no one anywhere in the forest noticed the great silver wolf who came to stand beside that brown, lop-eared carcass. But the wolf did come. And he stood there. Without moving or saying a word. All Christmas Day. Until it was night. And then he disappeared into the forest.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Martin Bell
Book: Way of the Wolf
ISBN: 978-0345305220
Publisher: Ballantine Books
Date (Month/Year): April 1983

AWARD HISTORY

2008 National Qualifier

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